

Job Description

Title	Details
Job title	Postdoctoral Research Fellow in Political Inequality, Polarization, and Computational Social Science
Department/Unit	Politics & IR
Job Type	Temporary – 36 months
Grade	6
Accountable to	Dr Miriam Sorace, Associate Professor in Comparative Politics
Accountable for	N/A
Vacancy reference	49676/AS/SPPE/20240930

Purpose

The Department of Politics and International Relations, University of Reading welcomes applications for a full-time, 3-year **Postdoctoral Research position in Political Inequality, Polarization, and Computational Social Science** for the UKRI-funded project 'DIVIDED: Inequality and Polarization Prevention' (PI: Dr Miriam Sorace).

DIVIDED will be an in-depth study of the relationship between economic inequality and political polarization, requiring extensive data collection and experimental/simulation work. The postdoctoral research fellow will be involved as a co-author in the project's academic and non-academic publications. Partners of the project include the London School of Economics (LSE) Data Science Institute (DSI), the UK Labour's Party HQ Data and Insight team, Opinium, the European Election Studies, the social media company Meta (and its computational social science team). There are currently 4 secondment opportunities built into the programme, two at the LSE DSI, one at Opinium and one in the data and targeting team of UK Labour Party HQ, with plans to extend further secondment/consultancy calls to governmental units and other political organisations. The successful candidate will spend a year at the LSE DSI, where they can avail of training and library resources, and be embedded into the LSE DSI industry networks and academic community.

We are seeking to appoint a highly motivated computational social scientist with demonstrable potential to produce exciting, innovative, and methodologically rigorous research in political economy/political behaviour, with very strong expertise in quantitative and computational methods. Advanced knowledge of and experience using R is required. The successful candidate will have a PhD in Political Science, Data Science, Economics, or a related field.

The department is a friendly and supportive place which has performed very strongly in the last two REF assessments. We are strongly committed to diversity and inclusion and welcome and

encourage applications from women, racialised minorities, and other groups who remain under-represented in the department and in academia more broadly.

Team Structure

The successful candidate will closely work with the PI (Dr Miriam Sorace) and her network of project partners (UK Labour Party, Meta, LSE DSI, Opinium, the European Election Studies). They will be part of the core project team including the PI and a PhD student, as well as of the political behaviour and comparative politics cluster in the Department.

The postdoctoral position and the wider team are based in the Department of Politics and International Relations, a small but dynamic department with internationally-recognised strengths in Comparative Politics, Political Theory, International Relations, and Strategy. We came 6th highest in the UK for research outputs in the 2021 REF (Politics and International Studies, when scoring by Output GPA), having been =10th on the same measure in 2014 (see <https://www.ref.ac.uk/>).

Current research specialisms within our Comparative Politics cluster include American politics and foreign policy, African politics, British politics, European and EU politics, public policy, interest groups, gender and politics, political economy, comparative political behaviour, poverty and political participation, religion and politics, research methods, electoral behaviour, political representation, political psychology, and politics and climate change.

The Department of Politics and International Relations offers two single Honours undergraduate programmes (Politics and International Relations; and War, Peace, and International Relations), a range of Joint Honours programmes (with Economics, History, Philosophy, English Literature, and Modern Languages), and several taught MA/MSc programmes (in Public Policy, International Relations and Diplomacy, and Conflict and International Security). We also have a thriving PhD community and participate in both ESRC and AHRC Doctoral Training Partnerships. In addition, we partner with Henley Business School to deliver the British Army's Higher Education Pathway, providing bespoke online BSc and MSc degrees in Leadership and Strategic Studies to early-career Army officers.

We host an active research community comprising both staff and PhD students and run regular research seminars across our teaching terms. We actively encourage inter-disciplinary research and members collaborate regularly with colleagues from across the university and around the world. We welcome applications for flexible working, including from parents and carers, and offer a range of support and mentoring schemes for staff, including teaching relief for early career scholars. Further information about the Department is available at www.reading.ac.uk/politics.

The Department is part of the newly formed School of Philosophy, Politics, and Economics, the predecessor to which was awarded an Athena SWAN Bronze Award in May 2021 and recently conducted a Race Equality Review. Information on wellbeing, inclusion, diversity and equality in the School is available at <https://www.reading.ac.uk/speir/wellbeing-inclusion-diversity-and-equality>.

The Role

The candidate will be expected to collect and clean big datasets, to produce advanced quantitative analyses, literature reviews and methodology papers or methodological briefs, as well as papers on various aspects of economic inequality and/or political polarization, as required by the principal investigator. The successful candidate will be expected to liaise with project partners and affiliated academics as appropriate to their level and their contributions, and to deliver presentations of findings to stakeholders and academic events as required.

The main duties and responsibilities of the Postdoctoral Research Fellow will include:

- Working alongside the PI and Opinium in trialling and testing gamification in mass surveys and in designing and carrying out all required statistical and experimental analyses required by the needs of the project;
- Supporting in data architecture/infrastructure work, helping to collect, clean and organise large datasets on economic inequality and social networks as required by the needs of the project;
- Supporting in the writing up of the research results from the various work-packages into academic articles;
- Pursuing an exciting, ambitious, and innovative research agenda in political behaviour, political economy, and/or in survey and social science methodology;
- Undertaking Continuing Professional Development in relation to research and research methods required by the project, and, optionally, additional areas (impact, teaching, etc.) of interest to the applicant;
- Supporting team members and colleagues in attending regular team meetings and providing academic/methodological support and advice to team and colleagues as required.

Supervision received

The post holder will report to the PI of the project (Dr Miriam Sorace) and will also receive mentoring from another established member of the PIR team, as well as from the extensive network of partners of the project (including the UK Labour Party, the LSE DSI, Meta, Opinium, and the executive board of the European Election Studies). The post holder will also receive general guidance from the Head of Department and Research Division Leader.

The successful candidate will be offered the opportunity (and time) to take part in UoR training offered as part of the *Doctoral and Research College* and through the *People Development* programme. Through this they can avail of the University's world-leading coaching and mentoring programme and of skills such as knowledge transfer and entrepreneurship, management and leadership, grant-writing and resume/CV building. They will also be included in the modules from the National Centre for Public Engagement on managing impact and knowledge exchange. The career training programme will be tailored according to the candidate's relevant needs and career stage. Funds will be earmarked for any potential methods training the team member requires (e.g. for participation in the Essex Summer School) and for participation to leading academic conferences.

DIVIDED has currently 4 secondment opportunities in-built into the programme, two at the LSE DSI, one at Opinium and one in the data team of UK Labour Party HQ and will open up secondment/consultancy calls to other political organisations. The candidate can therefore avail of these invaluable opportunities for supervision and networking.

Supervision given

N/A.

Contact

The role will be within the Department of Politics & International Relations, working alongside professional and academic colleagues. Specific tasks may require contact with a range of external bodies.

Terms and conditions

This is a full-time, temporary post (36 months), tenable interview.

This document outlines the duties required for the time being of the post to indicate the level of responsibility. It is not a comprehensive or exhaustive list, and the line manager may vary duties from time to time which do not change the general character of the job or the level of responsibility entailed.

Date assessed:

Person Specification

Job Title	School/Department
Postdoctoral Research Fellow	SPPE/PIR

Which stage these Criteria be assessed - compulsory

A = Application

I = Interview

P = Presentation/Pre task/Other (delete and amend as appropriate)

Criteria	Essential	Desirable
Skills Required	- Strong command of quantitative and computational methods/modelling (A/I) - Advanced knowledge of and experience using R (A/I) - Excellent data science/data management skills (A/I)	- Experience with geo-spatial analysis software and techniques (A/I) - Experience with AWS and GitHub (A/I) - Experience with simulation and computer games research/literature (A/I)
Attainment	- PhD in Political Science, Data Science, Economics or related field. (A/I) - An exciting and ambitious research agenda in political behaviour, or political economy, or econometrics/ social science methodology (A/I)	Published research outputs in political behaviour, or political economy, or econometrics/ social science methodology (A/I)
Knowledge	Expertise in political behaviour or political economy research (A/I)	
Relevant Experience	Ability to conduct excellent, methodologically rigorous research and to carry out statistical analyses for academic publications (A/I)	
Disposition	- Enthusiastic team player (I) - Personable in dealings with students, colleagues and wider stakeholders (I) - Supportive of diversity and inclusion initiatives (I)	Interested in seeking research funding, disseminating research, and developing potential pathways to impact (I)

Completed By Date: